the capital Beijing.

In 1859, a delegation of British and French arrived in Tianjin to travel to Beijing for the ratification of the Treaty of Tianjin by the Qing authorities. However, they were prevented from doing so and asked to travel by another designated route. When the delegation, accompanied by an armed escort, decided to press on regardless, it was attacked by Qing forces and suffered heavy losses. The British and the French returned with much larger forces and attacked the capital itself, inflicting heavy damage and losses, including the sacking of the Yuanmingyuan (Garden of Perfect Brightness) which was the summer retreat of the Qing royalty and generally known in the West as the Summer Palace. The British forces were mostly composed of Indian soldiers commanded by British officers. The sacking followed the detention, torture and killing of a delegation and an armed escort sent by the invading forces to negotiate a peaceful surrender. The escort included several Indian soldiers, who were also killed. In retaliation, the British High Commissioner to China, Lord Elgin, ordered the burning down of the entire palace complex, which included a series of buildings stretching back to the Yuan dynasty and added to by subsequent dynasties. The ruins visible today belong to the reign of the Qianlong emperor, when a set of European-style buildings and gardens were added. These were designed by the Jesuit priest Castiglione and an architect, Michel Benoit. The Yuanmingyuan was burned down over three days, and its vast treasures in ancient bronze, porcelain and paintings were looted by the invaders, mainly the British. According to UNESCO, the precious objects looted from the palace are spread over many private collections and in forty-seven museums around the world. This was a high point in China’s ‘century of humiliation’. While the Treaty of Tianjin was ratified by the Qing emperor, further concessions were wrested from the Chinese. The territory of Kowloon on the Chinese mainland, adjacent to Hong Kong, was ceded to Britain in perpetuity.

Further indignities followed at the hands of the Western powers, with Russia and Japan joining in to share the spoils. In 1858, Tsarist Russia threatened to open a new front in the north while China was embroiled in the Second Opium War. The price paid by China to avoid a conflict with